

worked hard to keep it off the screen as much as possible. Instead of the full-blown orchestral swoons for which he would later become famous, composer John Williams employs a jaggedly minimalist musical score to herald the approach of the shark; the result, a kind of panicked heartbeat, is the most haunting movie motif since the stabbing strings in Alfred Hitchcock's *Psycho* (1960).

Claustrophobia

As the narrative moves into its final act, the big showdown with the great white, its trio of heroes journeys out to sea—but Spielberg narrows his focus on their tiny fishing boat, the *Orca*, and the story shrinks to a human drama.

For all the movie's snapping shark jaws, exploding gas canisters, and severed heads bobbing toward the screen, the most memorable scene in *Jaws* is nothing more spectacular than three men talking: Chief Brody, shark expert Hooper (Richard Dreyfuss), and psychotic sea dog Quint (Robert Shaw) share a late-night drink below deck. They compare scars and sing songs, and eventually the conversation turns dark, as Quint tells the chilling



story of the sinking of the USS *Indianapolis* in World War II. "Eleven hundred men went into the water, three hundred and sixteen men came out," he growls. "The sharks took the rest."

Quiet before the storm

The *Indianapolis* speech is a moment of quiet that gets under our skin, so when that fake-looking mechanical shark-prop rises out of the ocean we see it as the director intended: a monster imbued with

With the *Orca* sinking and the shark about to swallow Brody, he has one final desperate plan to kill it in a spectacular finale.

awesome terror. Spielberg is a canny showman, and he knows that roller coasters rely on a lull before each stomach-churning plunge. It's a mark of his genius that *Jaws* contains more lulls than plunges, yet is remembered for its shock horror and white-knuckle action adventure. ■



Steven Spielberg Director

Born in Cincinnati, Ohio, in 1946, Steven Spielberg has been a household name for four decades. An all-American storyteller with a European eye, he has made some of the most successful movies of all time. With *Jaws*, his first hit, he invented the "event movie." His enthusiasm for the silver screen led him to make the *Indiana Jones* series, a homage to 1930s action adventure serials, while his family fable *E.T.* proved he was a master of emotional

drama. In 1993, he told a true story of heroism during the Holocaust with *Schindler's List*. Since then he has balanced historical drama with special-effects spectacles.

Key movies

1975 *Jaws*
1978 *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*
1982 *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*
1993 *Schindler's List*